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PSY 101: Introduction to Psychology - Mind, Behaviour and Evidence

What psychology actually studies, and how to evaluate a claim about behaviour

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Social Sciences
Psychology | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Psychology freshers arrive with strong intuitions and weak methods. This pack introduces the major perspectives, learning and memory, developmental and social psychology, and the research reasoning needed to tell evidence from anecdote.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish the biological, cognitive, behavioural, psychodynamic, humanistic and sociocultural perspectives.
- Explain classical and operant conditioning and observational learning with examples.
- Describe models of memory and reasons forgetting occurs.
- Evaluate a psychological claim using basic research-design criteria.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Perspectives and methods

Psychology is the scientific study of behaviour and mental processes, and it approaches questions from several angles.

- Biological: genes, brain structures and neurotransmitters.
- Cognitive: attention, perception, memory, language and problem solving.
- Behavioural: observable responses and consequences.
- Psychodynamic: unconscious conflict and early experience, historically influential but harder to test.
- Humanistic: growth, self-concept and personal agency.

- Sociocultural: how groups, culture and context shape behaviour.

> **Correlation is a clue, not a proof**
> A relationship between two variables does not establish direction or cause. Ask whether the study was experimental, randomised and controlled.

Learning and memory

Learning is a change in behaviour or knowledge resulting from experience; memory is the encoding, storage and retrieval of information.

- Classical conditioning: a neutral stimulus becomes associated with a meaningful one, as in Pavlov's dogs.
- Operant conditioning: behaviour is shaped by reinforcement and punishment.
- Observational learning: we learn by watching models, especially those we admire.
- Memory stages: sensory memory, short-term or working memory and long-term memory.
- Forgetting may result from encoding failure, decay, interference or retrieval failure.
- Spaced practice and retrieval practice are among the best-supported study techniques.

Development, personality and social behaviour

Human behaviour is shaped across the lifespan and in the presence of others.

- Piaget described cognitive stages; Vygotsky emphasised social scaffolding and the zone of proximal development.
- Erikson framed development as a sequence of psychosocial conflicts.
- Personality is described through traits; the Big Five model is widely used.
- Conformity, obedience and group influence can override individual judgement.
- Attribution explains how we assign causes to behaviour, often with bias in our own favour.
- Prejudice involves attitudes; discrimination involves behaviour.

Psychology as a science of behaviour and mind

Psychology studies behaviour and mental processes using empirical methods. Its authority comes from method, not from intuition: a claim about memory, emotion or personality must be testable and must survive attempts to falsify it. This is why psychology is a science subject with statistics in the curriculum, not a branch of philosophy.

The main perspectives each explain part of the picture. Biological approaches examine brain, genes and hormones. Cognitive approaches model attention, memory and problem-solving as information processing. Behavioural approaches study observable responses to environment. Psychodynamic approaches examine unconscious conflict. Humanistic approaches emphasise growth and meaning. Social approaches study how presence of others changes behaviour.

No single perspective explains everything, and a good answer uses more than one while stating what each leaves out.

Research methods and why they matter

Experiments manipulate an independent variable and measure a dependent variable while controlling confounds, which allows causal claims. Correlational studies measure relationships without manipulation, which does not. The most common error in student work - and in journalism - is treating a correlation as a cause.

Sampling determines what a result can be generalised to. A study of fifty first-year students in one department supports conclusions about that group, and only cautiously about others. Replication is what turns a finding into knowledge.

Ethics is not paperwork. Informed consent, avoidance of harm, confidentiality, the right to withdraw, and careful debriefing where deception was used are conditions of doing the research at all.

> **Correlation is not causation**
> Ice-cream sales and drowning rise together. Both follow temperature. Before accepting a causal claim, ask what third variable could produce both.

Core findings worth knowing

Memory is reconstructive, not a recording. Recall is shaped by schemas, and confident memory can be wrong; eyewitness identification is therefore weaker evidence than courts once assumed. Spacing and retrieval strengthen memory more than rereading.

Classical conditioning pairs a neutral stimulus with an unconditioned one until the neutral stimulus elicits the response; operant conditioning shapes behaviour through reinforcement and punishment. Both explain far more of everyday habit than people expect.

Social psychology documents conformity, obedience, bystander effects and attribution biases. These findings are uncomfortable because they locate the cause of behaviour in situations rather than character, which is why they are frequently misused to excuse individuals. A careful answer distinguishes explanation from excuse.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Designing a simple experiment

Test whether background music affects reading comprehension.

1. State the hypothesis with a direction.
2. Define the independent variable: silence, music with lyrics, instrumental music.
3. Define the dependent variable: score on the same comprehension test.
4. Assign participants randomly to conditions.
5. Control confounds: same text, same time of day, same duration, headphones at equal volume.
6. Analyse the group means and report the limitation: one session, one text, small sample.

> **What to carry forward**
> Random assignment, one changed variable, defined measure. That is an experiment.

2. Reading a study report critically

A headline says "students who sleep less score higher". Assess it.

1. Find the design: correlational or experimental?
2. Check the sample: who, how many, where?
3. Look for confounds: study habits, course difficulty, part-time work.
4. Check the effect size, not just significance.
5. Ask whether the direction could be reversed - poor performance causing stress and less sleep.
6. State what the study can and cannot support.

> **What to carry forward**
> Design, sample, confounds, effect size, direction. Five questions for any headline.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish experimental from correlational designs and the claims each permits.

15 marks

1. Define manipulation and control in experiments.
2. Explain why correlation cannot establish causation.
3. Give an example of each design.
4. State the role of random assignment and third variables.

Q2. Explain reconstructive memory and its implications for eyewitness testimony.

15 marks

1. Define reconstructive memory and schemas.
2. Describe the misinformation effect with a study example.
3. Show the implication: confidence and accuracy diverge.
4. State procedural safeguards: lineups, blind administration, caution in courts.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Independent variable. The factor an experimenter manipulates.

Dependent variable. The outcome measured in an experiment.

Confound. An uncontrolled factor that could explain the result.

Random assignment. Allocating participants to conditions by chance to reduce bias.

Correlation. A statistical relationship between two variables, not evidence of causation.

Replication. Repeating a study to test whether a finding holds.

Schema. A mental framework that organises knowledge and shapes recall.

Classical conditioning. Learning in which a neutral stimulus comes to elicit a response through pairing.

Operant conditioning. Learning shaped by reinforcement and punishment of behaviour.

Bystander effect. Reduced helping when others are present.

Informed consent. Agreement to participate given with knowledge of risks and purpose.

Effect size. The magnitude of a difference or relationship, distinct from statistical significance.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Perspectives

Explanatory frames.

- Summarise six perspectives in one line each.
- Explain one behaviour from three perspectives.
- State what each leaves out.

Week 2 - Methods

Design.

- Identify design in three abstracts.
- Design a simple experiment.
- List five confounds you controlled.

Week 3 - Findings

Memory and learning.

- Explain reconstructive memory.
- Apply spacing and retrieval to your own study.
- Describe one conditioning example from daily life.

Week 4 - Critique

Evidence.

- Assess one media psychology claim.
- Check sample and design.
- Write a 15-mark timed answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introductory psychology textbook covering methods, memory, learning and social psychology.
- A research methods chapter on experimental design and ethics.
- A review article on the misinformation effect.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between negative reinforcement and punishment?

Answer: Negative reinforcement increases a behaviour by removing an unpleasant stimulus; punishment decreases a behaviour by adding or removing a stimulus.

2. Why is a correlational study weaker than an experiment for causal claims?

Answer: Correlation does not control confounding variables or establish the direction of effect; an experiment manipulates the independent variable and controls alternatives.

3. Name two evidence-based study techniques.

Answer: Spaced practice and retrieval practice. Interleaving and elaboration are also supported.

4. Distinguish prejudice from discrimination.

Answer: Prejudice is a prejudgement or attitude; discrimination is behaviour that treats people unequally on that basis.

5. What is the zone of proximal development?

Answer: The gap between what a learner can do alone and what they can do with skilled guidance, where learning is most effective.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write one-sentence summaries of all six perspectives.
- [ ] Design a simple classical-conditioning example from campus life.
- [ ] Draw the memory model and label three causes of forgetting.
- [ ] Explain why an experiment supports causal claims better than a survey.
- [ ] Learn the Big Five traits with one descriptor each.
- [ ] Define prejudice, stereotype and discrimination distinctly.
- [ ] Critique one popular psychology claim using evidence criteria.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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